

FAMILY BY CHOICE

Our Pasadena Campus adopted this phrase sometime back and I have come to really like it, *“Family by Choice”*. I have heard it said that *“One can pick their friends, our family, we are stuck with.”* This may be true in the natural, but it is far from true in the spiritual realm.

You have made this conference a priority for one of the following reasons:

- You are one of mine and/or Susan’s spiritual children...
- You desire to become a spiritual parent...
- You are looking for spiritual paternity...
- You want to know how to develop spiritual children...

(You want to sit in 12 hours of classes – NOT)

We live in a fatherless culture both outside and inside the church. What a tragedy! (A child gets

80% of its identity from its father – 20% of its identity comes from the nurturing of a mother)

Choosing a local church to attend is a difficult decision. In my opinion the following things should be considered in such a decision:

- What is the doctrine of the church?
- What is the church doing in local and world evangelism?
- What is the discipleship process?
- Who is leading the church? (Are they people of integrity?)
- What ministry opportunities do they offer?

Sadly, most of these decisions are made like this?

- What music do they sing?
- What does the show look like?
- What is the communication style of the Pastor?
- What ministries do they offer for my family?

- Do their service times fit our schedule?

The choosing of a spiritual family is of great consequence and should be entered into very cautiously.

Choosing to become a son or daughter to a spiritual mother and/or father is even more important. Choosing to become a spiritual parent in my opinion, is one of the most important decisions of our lifetimes. As such we should follow some guidelines in making these decisions.

Choosing a spiritual mother/father:

Trust - This word seems incredibly simple, but the importance of this word, in this context, cannot be overstated.

The first thing we should ask ourselves concerning choosing a spiritual parent is whether the person in consideration has a

LONG track record of trustworthiness?
(Example of throwing a baby in the air) (No novices allowed) (One must learn to be a spiritual son or daughter before becoming a spiritual parent) (The natural process is Infant – Toddler – Child – Adolescent – Teenager – Parent) The same is true spiritually – A proven track record of trustworthiness is absolutely essential.

Because we are making these people family by choice, we should ask the following questions:

- Have I logged enough time with this person to trust them with my future?
- Does this person have a long enough track record to prove they are a person who can be trusted?
- Do others trust this person?
- Is this person a self-promoter or a promoter of those around them?
- Who has this person raised up in the past?

- Are there things about this person that I am intentionally ignoring because I want to be in their “Family”?

Never ignore the tell-tale signs of a breach of trust. No one is perfect, but a person who is untrustworthy should not be chosen as a spiritual parent.

One cannot expect to confer trust upon someone who has not earned trust, expecting the added responsibility to develop a new level of trust.

Access – Many people want to choose a celebrity figure as their spiritual parent. Then they can boast that so and so in my spiritual mother or father. This process should never be a who’s who among the religious elite. This decision creates a family by choice.

You will no doubt meet people wealthier, more famous, more powerful, and more influential than your spiritual parents, but it is those you

have chosen to be accountable to, and call mom and dad, that give you the access into their lives, that will make a temporal and eternal difference in who you become. (I would rather be a Nordin than a Gates)

When a person grants you access into their lives, it is a sacrificial action on their part, not for their benefit, but for yours.

According to dictionary.com access = The ability, right, or permission to approach, enter, speak with, or use. When a spiritual leader agrees to become a spiritual parent, they:

- Give their spiritual children the ABILITY to look behind the scenes of their lives. They are ABLE to see the good, the bad, and the ugly!
- Give their spiritual children the RIGHT to everything they have and everything they know!
- Give their spiritual children the PERMISSION to become known as one of

their family. Family by choice! They are given PERMISSION to act and react as a family member of the spiritual parent. The spiritual children are given the PERMISSION to APPROACH when others are not granted access. (They are given the spiritual security codes of our lives)

- Give their spiritual children permission to SPEAK WITH the spiritual parent, even when the spiritual parent is not speaking with others. (Some calls we answer no matter what – Larissa – Malvern private line into my office – *“If you would come home, I would give you a big hug and kiss, and tell you I love you.”*)
- Give their spiritual children the ability to USE them as needed. My spiritual children can USE my knowledge, my resources, my influence, my rolodex... Etc... This is not permission for spiritual children to abuse the spiritual parent, but to USE their relationship to further the purpose God has

called the spiritual child to. All this happens because we have become family by choice!

Availability:

According to dictionary.com availability = The fact or quality of being close at hand and ready for use. A spiritual parent/child relationship should look much like the healthy relationship between a natural parent and a grown child. The parent is not there to suffocate the child's life and make all the decisions. Neither should the adult child infringe into the parent's life by constantly needing everything to be provided for them by the parent.

The spiritual parent/child should maintain a relationship that is close at hand and ready for use, at a moment's notice. The reason both parties are willing to engage in a mutually beneficial relationship is because we have become family by choice.

Impartation:

According to dictionary.com impartation = The fact or quality of being close at hand and ready for use. This is very similar to availability. The difference is that availability means that as a parent I am close at hand and available for use – BUT when a spiritual parent imparts, it is no longer passive – It is a decisive action that is taken at a particular time to pass something from one person to another (or from one generation to another).

A lot of folks in Christian circles do not believe one person can impart anything to another person.

Think of the relationships between:

- Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.
- Moses and Joshua
- Elijah and Elisha
- Paul and Timothy

In each of these instances, something was passed (Imparted) from one generation to another.

Abraham passed a family name, a nation and wealth to Isaac! Isaac in turn passed it to Jacob! (They also passed a lying spirit around)

Moses passed a nation ready to inherit a Promised Land to Joshua!

Paul passed the New Testament Church to Timothy!

CONCLUSION:

When choosing a spiritual family, choose spiritual parents who are:

- Trustworthy...
- Available...
- Accessable...
- And willing to impart what they have to you...

We are family by choice!

THE POWER OF RECIPROcity IN A FAMILY

Much has been written about:

- The need for spiritual fathers/mothers...
- The responsibilities of spiritual fathers/mothers...

Not much has been written about what it looks like to be a spiritual son or daughter who brings honor to the spiritual parents; to God; and to the Kingdom of God.

All healthy families have God honoring parents and obedient children, who desire to honor God and their parents. ***“Honor your father and mother and things will go well for you, and your day’s will be long on the earth.”*** (When I was growing up, I thought this Scripture meant, *“If I obeyed my parents they wouldn’t kill me.”*)

This verse not only applies in the natural, nuclear family, but in our family by choice, our spiritual family.

I have never found it difficult to be a natural father or a spiritual father, because I had such a great natural father and was introduced to my Heavenly father at a very early age. Growing up, I wanted to get married and have children. I wanted to be a father. I wanted six children! (The spirit was willing but the flesh was weak!)

The thrill of my life is to be a husband, father, and grandfather. The next greatest thrill in my life has been to be a spiritual father.

While it is not difficult for me to step into the role of a spiritual father, I have found that many who say they desire to be a spiritual son and/or daughter, have no concept of what their role looks like, or how they are to behave in their family of choice.

I want to take a little while and address a few very important things in the context of reciprocity within a family, natural or spiritual.

Reciprocity = A mutual exchange of service and benefits inside a relationship. So, reciprocity is a fancy way of saying *“In this is our family of choice, there is going to be some taking and giving.”*

In this family by choice, no one person is going to load up on benefits and shirk responsibility. At the same time no one will be allowed to serve constantly without being rewarded.

There is going to be some due benevolence in this family by choice. In all families it is good to enjoy the benefits, because the benevolence is going to come due at some point. Within a spiritual family - Responsibility = Benefits and Benefits = Responsibility!

This is what I desire to see come to pass in the Kingdom – Malachi 4:10 ***“He will turn the hearts of the fathers to the children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers.”***

Spiritual fathers/mothers are critical to the fulfillment of this prophecy, but so is the rise of sons and daughters.

Sometimes we want the spiritual fathers and mothers to step up, but we do not take responsibility to live as sons and daughters.

Both identities must rise up together in order for the healing of the land to take place. I really believe the last great awakening will be predicated on:

- Spiritual paternity...
- The five-fold ministry...
- The return of gifts of the Spirit... (Not just to the church but to the marketplace)

- Kingdom identity and purpose for the sons and daughters of the Kingdom...

If this is to happen, we must identify and empower spiritual fathers and mothers, and raise up spiritual sons and daughters. One can say all they want to, that they are a spiritual mother/father but unless they identify, invest in, resource, and empower, sons and daughters – They are barren and have no spiritual paternity.

One cannot be a father without having a son or daughter! One cannot be a mother without bearing a child! In order to have paternity one must pass their DNA to the next generation! Passing one's DNA to the next generation is more than being a sperm donor (Leader – Teacher – Preacher), it becomes a process of discipleship that lasts a lifetime!

Having said that, I must also say that the process of becoming a son or daughter is not something you connect to today and disconnect from when a new bright shiny object comes into view. Sons

and daughters stay in the orbit, and under the authority of a spiritual mother or father until death parts them. We stick together because we are family by choice!

A person who wants to be a spiritual son or daughter should give their spiritual parents the right to say:

- What they want to...
- When they want to...
- How they want to...
- Where they want to...

...and we give up the right to be offended!

Here are some indicators that one is ready to become a part of a family by choice, as a spiritual son or daughter.

Pursuit

This sets people apart from the rest pretty expeditiously. True sons and daughters are

passionate about being raised up, and will fulfill almost any requirements to do so.

True sons and daughters have a hunger and a passion that drives them to pursuit. They are constantly in pursuit of:

- Growth...
- Instruction...
- Development...
- Discipleship...

The identifying characteristic of a person who is ready to become a spiritual son or daughter is that they position themselves to learn and grow in everything they do. They crave growth and will do almost anything to see it come to pass in their lives!

One thing I have learned is that you can teach skills, you can impart tools of the Kingdom, but you cannot teach passion. Passion has to be stirred up from within the individual. A spiritual

mother or father can motivate you, and inspire you, but they cannot give you long term passion. You must connect to that from within. The “want to” is something that each of us has to cultivate in our own hearts. (Susan Paul having the children to pray that God would fix the want to of the adults)

If son-ship and daughter-ship is not born out of passion everything becomes cheap talk and everything invested is wasted.

A few years ago, I was praying and telling the Lord how much I wanted a closer walk with Him and he very plainly and boldly said, “*The proof of desire is pursuit.*” (You gotta want it, to win it, and we want it bad!) Don’t tell me how much you want to be a spiritual son or daughter, show me! (Richard and Joanna – Sit on the seat behind me for a year)

Sons and daughters reveal themselves because they seek out fathers and mothers to learn from. And they are willing to do whatever it takes to

get the investment from someone who has the spirituality and experience to raise them up into their purpose. They are passionate about becoming family by choice!

The level of effort a person is willing to put into the pursuit tells you who they really are. (When someone shows you who they are, believe them the first time)

If those who claim to want to be sons and daughters fail to pursue, they will also fail to launch!

In such a case the time, resources, and effort invested by spiritual mothers and fathers becomes a big waste of time. Time is the one thing I don't have to waste, nor does anyone else who would qualify to be a spiritual mother or father!

Service

Let me say that anyone who desires to be a spiritual mother or father, and has an agenda to do anything but invest, is not a mother or father,

they are deadbeat dads and moms, who are nothing more than opportunists. (People who misuse spiritual sons and daughters for their own gratification will have a special seat reserved in Hell)

On the other hand, a son or daughter should have no agenda but to add value to others. Sons and daughters don't feel the need to push their resume and flaunt their titles. They know their spiritual parents will make a place for them when the time is right, because they are family by choice!

Sons and daughters don't get involved in comparison or competition with others, because they know their position with their spiritual parents, and when others succeed, it doesn't diminish the role of the son or daughter, it enhances it, because they are family by choice!

All sons and daughters have to go through seasons where they have to learn to serve in very humble ways. They often face times of the

wilderness where their heart is being tried, and their process is forming them, through humble service. Those seasons of serving are designed to build their heart for the long term.

Humble service is a characteristic of one being ready to become a son or daughter and being family by choice.

Submission to authority

How a person responds to authority is one of the greatest indicators of how far they will go in life and ministry. Submission and honor to authority identifies whether or not people will live as slaves or sons.

Authority is God's environment to break rebellion, pride and stubbornness, out of our lives. Rebellion is almost always an attitude before it is an activity.

We are told in Scripture to respond to authority in the following ways:

- Submit... (Submit means to stand under)

- Obey... (This literally means to allow your spiritual mother and father to act as a governor, judge or final authority in your life)
- Honor... (Preferring others – Deflecting credit – Accepting blame)

As a son or daughter, when we respond correctly to authority, we give ourselves and those around us greater room for promotion, blessing, and overall growth.

There are amazing talented people in the Kingdom of God. But can they get under someone's authority? Can they lead but also obey (With a good attitude)? Can they deflect credit and take unnecessary blame? (My experience with Bro. Granberry)

If one is continuing to struggle with spiritual authority, they are not ready to be a son or daughter.

Over the years, I have had hundreds of people tell me their dreams and goals. As I listen to them, most of the descriptions talk about forming their own business, starting their own church, or forming their own ministry. Few have mentioned “serving and learning under someone” as a part of their journey.

We’ve become so independently minded that we have no clue how to submit ourselves under authority figures.

Accepting correction

One of God’s litmus tests for sonship is the arena of correction. Hebrews 12:6 ***“For whom the Lord loves He chastens, And scourges every son whom He receives.”***

When I talk about correction, I am not speaking of coming under an abusive eldership. I am speaking of not just ALLOWING a spiritual authority to correct us, I am speaking of WELCOMING the correction!

Correction will either make us bitter or better. If it makes us bitter, we have hit a lid in our lives. If we welcome it and it makes us better, yesterday's ceiling becomes today's floor!

Recently the Lord said to me, *“If you can't be called out, you can't be called on!”*

Correction is usually the biggest and final test in the process of developing a son's or daughter's heart.

Correction keeps us from being ignorant to the blind spots in our lives. Blind spots that are left unattended are almost always fatal in the pursuit of purpose.

Conclusion:

Only time will tell whether a person can truly become a son or daughter. Far too many jump out during the process. Others decide they can do things better than their parents, and cut the cord. I have never personally witnessed a person cut the cord, with a person who was supposed to

be their spiritual mother or father, who went on and succeeded without a boat load of problems.

The process cannot be rushed. Relationship, credibility and trust must be built over time. The seasoning of time will tell if someone is really serious about walking as a powerful son or daughter within their family of choice.

I often wonder when sons and daughters walk away, what was at the root of their exit? I have decided the process revealed their true heart!

(Do the cord illustration here)